

Jindal of Louisiana" but not everyone is happy with his conservative Republican views. Many feel betrayed by what they see as his distancing himself from Indian heritage by embracing Christianity and rejecting Hindu faith, not to mention his extreme Right stand on a variety of social issues—from creativism to abortion to gun control. Jay Chaudhuri, president of Indian American Leadership Initiative (IALI), a network of Democrats, says, "It is exciting to see someone who looks and speaks like me, being elected to

Americans are also uncomfortable with his conversion to Christianity and name change from Piyush to Bobby, although it is not an official name change. Jindal is a complex person and no one seems quite sure of his motivations but one thing seems clear: he is first and foremost a Louisianan.

Born in Baton Rouge after his father, a civil engineer and his mother who was doing PhD in nuclear physics arrived there from Delhi, he once recalled, "India certainly had a strong impact on my life in terms of food,

"My grandfather had passed away. It was the first time I had thought about life and the importance of religious beliefs. I felt this was how God was calling me to worship Him," he says. His parents, he says, were supportive. Ravi Sakhuja, president of Indian American Forum for Political Action, a national non-partisan organisation, says: "I think no matter what our political inclination may be, most of us are delighted he's there. He picked an image as a competent administrator and gave people the hope that he was a good man to bet on." He adds, "The fact that he was born Hindu and changed to Christianity may be an issue with some people but he may not have got this far if he had played on a Hindu platform. I'm not saying he did that intentionally. There may have been a change in his thought process because he grew up here."

The key phrase seems to be "grew up here". There are many young Indian-Americans who are born here and live American lives but have imbibed Indian values. Asked whether he had retained his Indian heritage, he said, "I'm married to an Indian-American. Our heritage is certainly an important part of how we are raising our children. But every family will have a different answer to that question and that's normal. That's the way it should be." Jindal is under the public microscope but scores of young Indian-Americans here change their names, religion and do not wear their Indianness on their sleeve. But does that make them any less Indian? He has certainly emphasised on the Indian values of hard work and education. Many in the community are still glowing with the victory of a native son who has accomplished a difficult first and shown that drive and dedication can get one to the top. "I think no matter what your political leanings are or which religion you follow, you have to root for him," says Sakhuja. "He represents Indians here and creates the hope for us. We say we don't have a chance but well, there it is."

For all that, as he steps into the Governor's mansion in New Orleans at the end of a hard-fought battle, Jindal himself knows that a tougher battle lies ahead.



Many Indian-Americans are uncomfortable with Jindal's extreme Right stand on several social issues.

the highest office in Louisiana. But professionally, his stand on social issues would make many Indian-Americans uncomfortable."

To really understand the gamut of emotions Indian-Americans feel about him, one would have to turn to the blogs where increasingly opinions are bandied about. Sepia Mutiny, a popular blog among young South Asians had hundreds of comments on a post about Jindal—all largely complimentary. "This guy is on his way to becoming one of the smartest and possibly most influential champions of hatred, ignorance and bigotry in this country," wrote one blogger, "And am I supposed to drink to him because we trace our common heritage to a pool of 1.3 billion people?" Many Indian-

culture and growing up." He visited India often when his grandparents were alive. But he grew up in Baton Rouge, not India, as a dark skinned boy in the Deep South. At the age of four, he jettisoned his given name Piyush for Bobby, something which many young Indian-Americans do. It was all about assimilation and adaptation. Yet ask him about his growing-up days and he has happy memories, "I never felt anything other than welcomed at school and among friends."

Jindal grew up in a Hindu household in an American town. In India, religion is absorbed by osmosis but in this Southern town, surrounded by churches, there were no temples at that time. Around the time he was 14 or 15, he discovered his Christian faith.